

Aaron Braundmeier

636-627-9619 | aaron@braundmeier.com | [LinkedIn](#) | [braundmeier.com](#) | [k8s.guide](#)

Director of Engineering | **Kubernetes & Cloud-Native Platforms** | **Fleet-Scale Infrastructure** | **DevSecOps**

Engineering leader with 10+ years building and running cloud-native infrastructure at companies where the platform either works or the business stops. Currently directing Kubernetes engineering at Mastercard across a 400+ cluster fleet, driving a wholesale shift away from bespoke internal tooling toward maintainable, industry-standard platforms. Background spans distributed systems, payment infrastructure, multi-cloud operations, and developer experience. Known for hiring sharp engineers, cutting through complexity, and shipping platforms that teams actually want to use.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Mastercard

Director of Kubernetes Engineering | 2025 – Present

- Own Kubernetes platform strategy and technical direction across a fleet of **400+ clusters**, setting architecture standards for cluster topology, workload deployment patterns, admission control, and multi-tenancy.
- Running down years of accumulated technical debt by replacing homegrown pipelines and deployer services with purpose-built tooling: **Argo**, **cert-manager**, **OPA Gatekeeper**, and **Backstage**, each chosen for longevity and community support over short-term convenience.
- Leading the migration off **EOL NGINX Ingress** to **Traefik** across the full cluster fleet, closing a real CVE exposure at scale while standardizing on a modern, actively maintained ingress controller.
- Built a team-wide AI operations layer using **Claude Code**: engineers invoke custom **Claude Commands** against a structured internal repo of IaC, runbooks, and incident postmortems to accelerate troubleshooting, draft documentation, and feed fixes back into the same knowledge base.
- Manage and grow a team of senior platform engineers; own hiring, technical direction, and cross-org alignment with security, compliance, and application engineering.

CVS Health

Senior Engineering Manager | 2024 – 2025

- Built and led a global engineering organization of **50+ engineers** across two managers, responsible for modernizing pharmacy systems that process millions of prescriptions daily.
- Defined the technical roadmap and led execution on a full migration from legacy monolithic applications to **GKE**-based microservices backed by **Cloud Spanner**, moving the stack onto infrastructure teams could actually operate and scale.
- Wrote a **Python** tool that pulled live data from **Jira**, **SonarQube**, **Snyk**, **GitHub**, and **ArgoCD** into a single executive dashboard, giving leadership real visibility into delivery health, security posture, and velocity without chasing spreadsheets.
- Deployed the dashboard to **GKE** via **ArgoCD** with a **GitHub Actions** pipeline, making it the team's first fully GitOps-managed internal tool.

VMware

Engineering Manager | 2021 – 2024

- Led the engineering team building the **Tanzu Developer Portal**, the primary developer-facing surface for enterprise Kubernetes environments across VMware's customer base.
- Owned multi-cloud cluster operations across **GCP**, **Azure**, and **AWS** for product and demo environments, maintaining **99.99%** availability while keeping overhead manageable for a lean team.
- Cut unplanned downtime by **30%** by overhauling incident response practices: cleaner runbooks, tighter alerting thresholds, and structured postmortem reviews that actually changed behavior.
- Established engineering standards for cloud-native development across teams and ran the cross-team coordination needed to get them adopted, not just published.

Mastercard

Engineering Manager | 2018 – 2021

- Managed three teams building and operating API-driven payment lifecycle products processing millions of daily transactions across Mastercard's global network.
- Drove the migration from monolithic payment services to a microservices architecture, reducing deployment risk and giving individual teams the ability to ship independently.
- Served as a technical lead on the **Apple Card** backend integration, coordinating API contracts and launch readiness directly with Apple engineering.

Senior Big Data Engineer | 2016 – 2018

- Designed Hadoop-based pipelines for payment transaction analytics; worked with data security to ensure processing met compliance requirements at scale.

Distributed Systems Engineer | 2015 – 2016

- Scaled and automated Mastercard's global data center provisioning, cutting manual deployment time and reducing configuration drift across the fleet.

Systems Engineer | 2013 – 2015

- Deployed and managed enterprise macOS infrastructure via JAMF; built automation tooling that eliminated large categories of recurring manual work.

CERTIFICATIONS

Certified Kubernetes Administrator (CKA) | Certified Kubernetes Application Developer (CKAD)
Kubernetes and Cloud Security Associate (KCSA) | Kubernetes and Cloud Native Associate (KCNA)
Certified Argo Project Associate (CAPA) | AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner | Google Cloud Cybersecurity

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Orchestration & Platforms:	Kubernetes (EKS, GKE, AKS), Helm, Argo CD, Argo Workflows, Backstage
Networking & Security:	Traefik, cert-manager, OPA Gatekeeper, Falco, kube-bench, Prisma Cloud
Cloud & Infrastructure:	GCP, AWS, Azure, Terraform, Docker, Cloud Spanner
Observability & Delivery:	GitHub Actions, ArgoCD, SonarQube, Prometheus, Grafana
Languages & Tooling:	Python, Shell, SQL, GraphQL, REST APIs

SIDE PROJECTS

k8s.guide | Kubernetes Study Guide

Founder & Author | *Ongoing*

- Built and maintain a structured Kubernetes learning resource used by engineers preparing for CKA, CKAD, and CKS; covers internals, networking, security, and real-world operational patterns.

EDUCATION

Southern Illinois University – Edwardsville

B.S., Management Information Systems | 2013

VOLUNTEERING

Coach, St. Peters Hockey Club